8
I Do

‘Beckham. Here. I want a word.’

‘Victoria hates it up north…’

‘David is joining Arsenal…’

‘…or, if he isn’t, he’s going to buy a helicopter to fly up to Manchester three times a week.’

There was plenty of speculation when we bought our house just outside London. The truth was a lot simpler, but also a lot less controversial. The story needed to shift newspapers, I suppose, which meant that the boring and the obvious had to make way for something people could talk about. Actually, Victoria didn’t have a problem with Manchester at all or with me playing there. And as for me, I had absolutely no intention of ever leaving United. I think even the manager read more significance into us buying a new place than there was. He was aware of the gossip and pulled me to one side:

‘Why have you bought that?’

His main concern was probably that I might end up trying to commute from Essex for training. In fact, even after we talked, I think he spent a year or more believing that, secretly, that’s what I was doing. He didn’t realize the place was a building site. I did my best to explain:

‘London is where I’m from and that’s why I’ve bought a house there. When I finish playing, I’ll move back: my family’s in London and so are lots of our friends. That’s all it is. We’re a family now, boss: Mr and Mrs Beckham. We’ve got our first baby boy. And when I retire London will be the